

Ἰσαῖος ὁ ῥήτωρ

Isaeus the Orator and the Athenian Law of Inheritance

eul_aid: fge

Period: [Κλασική](#) [Classical](#)

Dialect: [Ἀττική](#) [Attic](#)

Domain: [Ῥητορική](#) [Oratory](#)

Format: [Λόγος](#) [Oration](#)

Isaeus was a professional speechwriter, or logographer, who worked in Athens during the first half of the fourth century BCE. He was a metic, a resident foreigner, and ancient sources suggest he may have come from Chalcis. His career focused exclusively on writing forensic speeches for private court cases, particularly complex disputes over inheritance and family property.

According to ancient tradition, he was a pupil of the rhetorician Isocrates and later a teacher of Demosthenes. None of the speeches he wrote for clients were delivered by him personally. Of the many speeches attributed to him, twelve survive essentially complete, all dealing with inheritance law. These works provide detailed examples of Athenian legal practice.

Modern scholars value his speeches as crucial historical sources for understanding family relationships, property rights, and social strategies in classical Athens. His style was noted for its clear argumentation and methodical use of evidence, including laws and witness testimony. While some ancient critics found his speeches lacking in emotional power, they praised his logical skill and pure Attic Greek. His technical expertise in constructing legal arguments is considered a significant influence on the development of Athenian oratory.

Works (13)

- [Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Κληρονομικῶν Ἀμφισβητήσεων](#) · [Fragments on Inheritance Disputes](#) · 19 passages
- [Υπὲρ Εὐφιλῆτου](#) · [In Defense of Euphiletus](#) · 11 passages
- [Περὶ τοῦ Ἁγνίου κλήρου](#) · [On the Holy Clergy](#) · 40 passages
- [Περὶ τοῦ Απολλοδώρου κλήρου](#) · [On the Lot of Apollodorus](#) · 35 passages
- [Περὶ τοῦ Ἀστυφίλου κλήρου](#) · [On the Lot of Astyphilus](#) · 30 passages
- [Περὶ τοῦ Κίρωνος κλήρου](#) · [On the Lot of Chiron](#) · 39 passages
- [Περὶ τοῦ Κλεωνύμου κλήρου](#) · [On the Lot of Cleonymus](#) · 34 passages
- [Περὶ τοῦ Δικαιογένους κλήρου](#) · [On the Lot of Dicaeogenes](#) · 40 passages
- [Περὶ τοῦ Μενεκλέους κλήρου](#) · [On the Lot of Menecles](#) · 35 passages
- [Περὶ τοῦ Νικοστράτου κλήρου](#) · [On the Lot of Nicostratus, Epilogue](#) · 23 passages
- [Περὶ τοῦ Φιλοκτήμονος κλήρου](#) · [On the Lot of the Covetous](#) · 48 passages
- [Περὶ τοῦ Πύρρου κλήρου](#) · [On the Pyrrhus' Lot](#) · 51 passages
- [Πρὸς Ξεναίνετον περὶ τοῦ Ἀριστάρχου κλήρου](#) · [To Xenaenetus-the Lot of Aristarchus](#) · 22 passages